

Belvedere Vodka

Poland is the home of Belvedere, yet has only been around for the past 19 years. Their distillery however has been in use for over 100 years. Situated in the small town of Żyrardów, west of Warsaw, two brothers – Dawid and Mejer Pines, established the 'Żyrardów Polmos (Belvedere) distillery in 1910. The distillery was originally home to the production of spirit and vodka and soon after World War 1, the distillery was purchased by the Dauman family who ran the business until the outbreak of World War 2. Once 1932 rolled around, all the equipment was modernized to become one of the most technologically advanced distilleries in Europe at that time. At the end of the war, the new communist regime nationalized Żyrardów along with 24 other vodka distilleries, all renamed 'Polmos' followed by the name of the nearest town (i.e. Żyrardów Polmos). During this time, vodka's including Wyborowa, Zubrowka and Luksusowa were all produced here amongst others.

After the end of communism, Polmos Żyrardów decided to create their own vodka that would distinguish them from the other Polmos distilleries. Belvedere was born. Named after the Belweder Palace in Warsaw, which itself translates as 'beautiful to see', it became the acid-etched drawing that embraces each Belvedere bottle. The first bottles of Belvedere vodka were produced in 1993, where it quickly gained a reputation in Poland. Around this time, the USA were in the midst of seeing a boom in premium spirits, and one American, Edward Jay Phillips who was a third generation liquor distributor, travelled to Poland in search for the next premium vodka. After discovering Belvedere, he created the Millennium Import Company in 1994 and acquired the sole US distribution rights where in 1996, Belvedere was launched to growing sales in the US. The distillery was privatised in 2001, where a year later, Louis Vuitton • Moët Hennessy (LVMH) purchased Millennium Imports with a 70% stake, and then fully purchased only 3 years later.

The production of Belvedere is rather a simple affair. Its base grain is a Polish 100% Dankowski Gold Rye, from the Mazovian soil in Żyrardów where it is slow fermented for several days. The raw spirit is distilled at several agricultural distilleries and sent to Polmos Żyrardow for rectification. The spirit then goes through a three column distillation process at the distillery. Belvedere use their own water source, an artesian well, where it is purified and then blended with the spirit of Belvedere until it reaches an ABV of 40%. The vodka is then filtered twice, once through a cellulose filter that will remove microscopic particles and then through an activated carbon filter. After filtration, the vodka is ready to be bottled, where it passes through 33 quality control checkpoints.

As the iconic bottles are filled they are individually inspected and hand finished with the application of the famous blue strip stamp. **Belvedere** – 40%

The nose embraces light floral notes with subtle hints of parma violets and vanilla. A full, round, smooth taste of vanilla creates a velvet texture on the palate, with hints of white pepper and spice coming through near the end. A long finish of clotted cream and almonds is rather welcoming.